



New look: The Indian hockey teams will be seen in saffron jerseys instead of their traditional blue kits starting this World Cup. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

saffron for its jersey colour has brought about unwarranted attention. India's recent track record, coupled with the unnecessary sideshow from HI, doesn't augur well for an improved showing heading into the World Cup. But a change in kit colour ought to help change that, doesn't it? Surely?

Head coach Craig Fulton will hope his decision-making has a definitive say in India's fortunes in what will be an increasingly competitive field. The South African has selected near-identical squads for both tournaments, with heavy emphasis on experience. The combined international caps of Harmanpreet Singh, Manpreet Singh, Mandeep Singh and Amit Rohidas make up over 41 per cent of total appearances in the 20-man squad.

India couldn't have asked for a better way to begin proceedings, being pooled together with Wales, England and Pakistan. But the new tournament format with two Pool stages mean India cannot afford a slow start. While England, which hasn't lost in 17 games this year, might give India a stern test, the Men in Saffron (this is going to need some getting used to) will feel they can notch up victories over Wales and Pakistan to progress into the second round. Should it do so, the real test to a potential podium finish will come in

Round 2, likely in the form of tough tests against Argentina and reigning Olympic champion Netherlands.

After a horrendous start to the Pro League campaign at home, India's results picked up in the Australian and European legs, adding creditable victories over Germany and the Netherlands.

Fulton, who places great emphasis on defensive solidity, would have been pleased with India's renaissance. In the opening eight games of the Pro League, teams sliced India open with ease, scoring 25 goals, while averaging 25 circle penetrations against it. In the final eight games, it tightened its structure and backline, conceding just 14, with circle penetrations coming down to 17 per game.

Another concern would have been how vulnerable India looked in the early stages of matches, often being dispossessed or seeing misplaced passes force turnovers in its own half. That issue seems to be getting slowly addressed — India conceded nine goals in the first quarters of the opening eight games, but that came down to just three on the European tour.

In goal, Krishan Pathak was long viewed as PR Sreejesh's replacement, but his sacking at the start of the year for disciplinary reasons has thwarted India's progress. Suraj Karkera and

Mohit H.S. have come along well after some shaky displays, but remain prone to errors.

India will hope it retains its good habits when it comes up against traditional favourites Belgium, Germany, the Netherlands and Australia, sides that are tactically sound with highly skilled technical players who can prove to be difference-makers.

Last edition's runner-up and co-host Belgium come into the tournament as the in-form side, having won the Pro League in style. Shane McLeod's side operates in a similar defensive counter-attacking style to India's, but the Red Lions manage to do it at a superior level.

Veteran forward Tom Boon and defender Alexander Hendrickx accounted for 34 of the 59 goals in the Pro League. Both provide a lethal threat from penalty corners (PC), too, with the pair tallying 22 from set-piece plays.

Their prowess is reflected in Belgium's efficiency from PCs, with the team boasting the best conversion rate (34.67 per cent) among all teams. Skipper Arthur van Doren continues to be the team's lynchpin in defence, with his ability to nullify attackers and his pinpoint passing from deeper areas.

Defending champion Germany (**facing page, below**) has undergone a significant squad overhaul since its triumph in Bhubaneswar, with only nine of the title-winning group and 11 of the Olympic silver-medal-winning group from the following year returning under head coach Andre Henning. While the recently concluded Pro League was among its worst in recent memory, it will be hard to discount Germany's tradition of turning up at big tournaments.

After losing out on gold at the Olympics, it avenged its defeat against rival Netherlands in the EuroHockey Championships final, thanks to Jean-Paul Danneberg's heroics in the penalty shoot-out.

Star midfielder Christopher Ruhr is the only player with over 200 caps in a squad that has an average age of just 25. Despite losing out on Gonzalo